

Analysing Argument: Persuasive Techniques

VCE English Units 3 and 4 — Reference table

A reminder for students: naming a technique earns no marks on its own. Strong analysis explains how the technique works within the wider argument — what it positions the intended audience to think or feel, and why the writer has placed it where they have. The examples below are constructed for illustration.

Appeals to emotion and values

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Appeal to fear	Warns of a threatening or damaging outcome if the reader does not accept the contention.	“Unless council acts now, our children will inherit streets choked by traffic and fumes.”	Positions readers to feel anxious about the consequences of inaction, so that supporting the writer’s proposal seems the only responsible, protective choice.
Appeal to family values	Invokes the reader’s role as a parent, child or family member and the desire to protect loved ones.	“What parent would knowingly send their child into a classroom like this?”	Encourages readers to judge the issue through the lens of protecting their own family, making opposition feel like negligence rather than disagreement.
Appeal to patriotism / national pride	Links the contention to shared national identity, symbols or values.	“This is not the fair go that Australians have always believed in.”	Invites readers to defend a national ideal, so that agreeing feels like an act of loyalty and disagreeing feels un-Australian.
Appeal to self-interest	Frames the argument in terms of direct personal benefit or loss to the reader.	“Every hour stuck in traffic is an hour stolen from your own weekend.”	Prompts readers to see a personal stake in an otherwise abstract issue, making them more likely to act.
Appeal to the hip-pocket nerve	A specific form of self-interest focused on money, taxes, rates or household costs.	“Ratepayers will foot the \$4.2 million bill for a footbridge nobody asked for.”	Positions readers as taxpayers being taken advantage of, generating resentment towards the opposing side.
Appeal to tradition / nostalgia	Draws on an idealised past or long-standing custom as a reason to preserve or restore something.	“For generations, Saturday morning sport has been a rite of passage in this town.”	Encourages readers to feel that something valuable is being lost, framing change as vandalism rather than progress.
Appeal to justice and fairness	Argues that a situation breaches principles of equity or a “level playing field”.	“It is simply not right that one school receives twice the funding of the school next door.”	Invites readers to feel moral indignation, positioning the writer as the defender of fairness.
Appeal to common sense	Presents the contention as self-evident to any reasonable person.	“Any sensible person can see that a two-hour commute is not sustainable.”	Discourages scrutiny by implying that disagreement would expose the reader as foolish or out of touch.
Appeal to authority / expert opinion	Cites recognised specialists, institutions or officials to lend weight to a claim.	“The Royal Children’s Hospital has warned repeatedly about the risks.”	Reassures readers that the position is credible and evidence-based, and makes disagreement seem uninformed.
Appeal to group loyalty / belonging	Constructs a shared community identity that the reader is invited to join.	“We in the western suburbs know exactly what neglect looks like.”	Creates solidarity between writer and reader, positioning opponents as outsiders who do not understand.

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Appeal to pity / compassion	Foregrounds the suffering or vulnerability of a person or group.	“Maria, seventy-eight and legally blind, now waits ninety minutes for a bus that once ran hourly.”	Elicits sympathy, making the reader feel that supporting the contention is an act of decency.
Appeal to responsibility / duty	Frames action as an obligation owed to others, often future generations.	“We owe it to the students who come after us to fix this now.”	Places a moral burden on readers, so that inaction feels like a failure of character.
Appeal to hope / optimism	Paints a positive vision of what is achievable.	“Imagine a foreshore where families gather instead of a fenced-off carpark.”	Encourages readers to invest emotionally in an appealing future and to associate the writer with it.
Appeal to guilt or shame	Suggests the reader is complicit in a wrong through silence or inaction.	“Every one of us who scrolled past that report shares a little of the blame.”	Makes readers uncomfortable with their own passivity, motivating them to act in order to relieve that discomfort.
Appeal to modernity / progress	Portrays the opposing view as outdated and the contention as forward-thinking.	“It is 2026, and we are still arguing about whether women deserve equal pay.”	Positions opponents as backward, so that agreement becomes a way of aligning oneself with progress.
Appeal to freedom and individual rights	Frames the issue as one of personal liberty or civil rights.	“No government should dictate what a family reads at the dinner table.”	Provokes resistance to perceived overreach, encouraging readers to defend their autonomy.
Appeal to security and safety	Emphasises the need for protection, order or stability.	“Residents deserve to walk to the station after dark without checking over their shoulder.”	Positions the proposal as a basic protection, making opposition appear indifferent to public wellbeing.

Language and word choice

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Emotive language	Word choices selected primarily for their emotional charge rather than their descriptive accuracy.	“The proposal will devastate a fragile, irreplaceable wetland.”	Heightens the reader’s emotional response so that the issue feels urgent and the stakes catastrophic.
Connotation	The associations a word carries beyond its literal meaning.	Describing protesters as a “mob” rather than a “gathering”.	Shapes the reader’s attitude towards a group before any evidence is offered, colouring the whole argument.
Labelling and naming	Assigning a loaded name or category to people, policies or ideas.	Calling the levy a “commuter tax” rather than a “network contribution”.	Fixes a negative frame in the reader’s mind that persists even when counter-evidence appears.
Inclusive language	First-person plural pronouns (“we”, “us”, “our”) that fold the reader into the writer’s position.	“Our streets, our schools, our responsibility.”	Blurs the line between writer and reader so the contention feels like a shared conviction rather than one person’s opinion.
Exclusive language	Third-person pronouns (“they”, “them”, “those people”) that separate the opposition from the reader.	“They sit in Spring Street and decide what our suburb needs.”	Creates an in-group and an out-group, encouraging readers to distrust the opposition on principle.
Colloquial language	Informal, everyday expressions and slang.	“Let’s be honest — the whole thing’s a dog’s breakfast.”	Builds rapport and makes the writer seem down-to-earth and trustworthy, like someone speaking plainly.
Formal register and technical jargon	Specialist or elevated vocabulary drawn from a professional field.	“The catchment’s hydrological load exceeds design tolerance.”	Signals expertise and authority, making the argument appear rigorous and difficult for a lay reader to

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			challenge.
Euphemism	A mild or vague expression substituted for something harsh.	Referring to job losses as “workforce realignment”.	Softens the reader’s reaction to an unpalatable reality, reducing the likelihood of outrage.
Dysphemism	A deliberately harsh or ugly term used in place of a neutral one.	Describing the development as “concrete sprawl”.	Intensifies the reader’s disgust, ensuring the subject is judged negatively before it is examined.
Cliche	A familiar, well-worn phrase.	“At the end of the day, actions speak louder than words.”	Offers instant, effortless agreement by drawing on a phrase the reader already accepts as true.
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration for effect.	“The queue at the clinic stretched halfway to the border.”	Amplifies the scale of the problem so readers perceive it as intolerable and demanding immediate attention.
Understatement / litotes	Deliberately downplaying something significant, often ironically.	“A fourteen-week wait for surgery is not ideal.”	Invites readers to supply the outrage themselves, which can feel more persuasive than being told what to feel.
Superlatives and absolutes	Words such as “never”, “always”, “everyone”, “worst” that admit no exceptions.	“This is the worst planning decision the shire has ever made.”	Projects certainty and closes down the possibility of qualification or middle ground.
High modality	Verbs and adverbs expressing certainty or obligation — “must”, “undoubtedly”, “will”.	“Council must reverse this decision immediately.”	Conveys conviction and urgency, positioning the contention as beyond reasonable dispute.
Low modality	Tentative language — “might”, “perhaps”, “it could be argued”.	“There may be room to reconsider the timeline.”	Makes the writer seem reasonable and open-minded, which can disarm a hostile reader.
Imperatives and direct address	Commands, and second-person address to the reader.	“Write to your member. Do it today.”	Converts agreement into action by making the reader feel personally instructed and accountable.
Neologism and coinage	Inventing a new word or phrase to name a phenomenon.	“The ‘commute-and-collapse’ generation.”	Gives the reader a memorable handle for the writer’s framing of the issue, making it easier to recall and repeat.
Allusion	A reference to a well-known text, event, person or story.	“This is a David-and-Goliath fight, and Goliath owns the land.”	Borrows the emotional and moral weight of the referenced story, casting the sides in familiar roles.
Pun and wordplay	Play on multiple meanings or similar-sounding words, common in headlines.	Headline: “Bridge over troubled ratepayers”.	Entertains the reader and lowers resistance, while compressing a judgement into a memorable phrase.
Slogan / sound bite	A short, rhythmic, repeatable phrase encapsulating the contention.	“Fund the future, not the freeway.”	Makes the argument portable and memorable, so it survives long after the details are forgotten.

Rhetorical and structural devices

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Rhetorical question	A question posed for effect rather than to elicit an	“How many more reports must gather dust before	Draws readers into constructing the answer

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	answer.	something changes?"	themselves, making them feel they have reasoned their way to the writer's position.
Repetition	Deliberate restatement of a word, phrase or idea.	"It is unsafe. It is unfair. It is unfinished."	Reinforces the key idea until it feels self-evident, and lends the prose a rhythm that carries the reader along.
Anaphora	Repetition of the same word or phrase at the start of successive clauses or sentences.	"We warned them in March. We warned them in June. We warned them again last week."	Builds cumulative momentum and a sense of mounting grievance.
Rule of three (tricolon)	Grouping ideas, images or examples in threes.	"Safer streets, shorter waits, stronger communities."	Creates a satisfying, complete-sounding rhythm that makes the claim feel thorough and well-considered.
Alliteration	Repetition of initial consonant sounds.	"A policy of delay, denial and disregard."	Makes phrasing memorable and emphatic, drawing the reader's attention to the words the writer most wants retained.
Antithesis	Balanced contrast of opposing ideas within a sentence.	"They promised transparency; they delivered silence."	Sharpens the contrast between the two sides, making the opposition's failure appear stark and deliberate.
Juxtaposition and contrast	Placing two contrasting situations, images or figures side by side.	A photograph of the new stadium beside a shot of the closed community pool.	Invites readers to draw an unfavourable comparison themselves, which feels like their own conclusion.
Metaphor	An implied comparison in which one thing is described as another.	"The budget is a house of cards."	Compresses a complex judgement into a vivid image, encouraging readers to accept the comparison's implications.
Extended metaphor	A metaphor sustained and developed across a passage.	A whole column framing the planning process as a slow-moving train wreck.	Structures the reader's understanding of the entire issue, so every detail is interpreted through the chosen frame.
Simile	An explicit comparison using "like" or "as".	"The consultation was like being asked to choose the colour of a wall already painted."	Makes an abstract complaint concrete and often faintly absurd, encouraging shared derision.
Analogy	An extended comparison to a simpler or more familiar situation.	"Cutting maintenance to save money is like skipping servicing to keep your car on the road."	Transfers the reader's confident judgement about the familiar case onto the unfamiliar one.
Personification	Attributing human qualities to an object, place or abstraction.	"The river has been strangled by a century of neglect."	Encourages readers to feel sympathy for a non-human subject, raising the emotional stakes.
Sarcasm	Mocking praise or comment whose intended meaning is the opposite of what is said.	"What a triumph of planning — a bus lane that ends in a roundabout."	Ridicules the opposition and invites readers to share the writer's scorn, positioning them as equally clear-sighted.
Irony	A gap between what is stated or expected and what is actually the case.	"The road safety forum was cancelled because delegates could not get there safely."	Exposes contradiction in the opposing position, undermining its credibility without direct attack.
Humour	Wit, absurdity or comic exaggeration used within an argument.	"The strategy runs to 240 pages, which is 239 more than the plan it replaces."	Makes the writer likeable and disarms resistance, so criticism is absorbed with less defensiveness.

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Anecdote	A brief personal story used to illustrate the argument.	"Last winter I watched a man in a wheelchair turned away from the only accessible entrance."	Converts statistics into a human face, making the issue emotionally real and difficult to dismiss.
Framing / defining the issue	Establishing at the outset what the debate is "really" about.	"This is not a debate about parking. It is a debate about who this city is for."	Controls the terms of the discussion, so the opposition is forced to argue on the writer's chosen ground.
Concession	Openly acknowledging a point in the opposing argument.	"Critics are right that the cost is significant."	Makes the writer appear fair-minded and balanced, increasing the reader's trust in what follows.
Rebuttal	Directly answering and dismantling an opposing argument.	"But the claim that the levy is temporary collapses the moment you read clause 14."	Reassures readers that objections have been considered and defeated, leaving no obvious escape from the contention.
Pre-emption / anticipating objections	Raising a likely counter-argument before the reader can.	"Some will say we cannot afford it. In fact, we cannot afford not to."	Defuses resistance before it forms and positions the writer as several steps ahead of the sceptic.
Call to action	A closing exhortation directing the reader to do something specific.	"Sign the petition before Friday's meeting."	Channels the emotion generated by the piece into a concrete behaviour, giving the reader an outlet.
Climactic ordering	Arranging points so they escalate in force towards the end.	Moving from inconvenience, to cost, to a child's injury.	Leaves readers with the most powerful impression at the point where the argument is meant to land.
Headline and opening hook	The title and first lines, engineered for impact.	"The bridge to nowhere — and the suburb paying for it"	Fixes the reader's interpretive frame before the argument begins and compels them to read on.

Evidence and support

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Statistics	Numerical data cited in support of a claim.	"Emergency department waits have risen 34 per cent since 2023."	Lends an air of objectivity and scale, making the problem seem measurable and therefore undeniable.
Research and studies	Reference to formal investigations, reports or peer-reviewed findings.	"A Monash University study tracked 4,000 commuters over five years."	Signals rigour, positioning the contention as grounded in fact rather than opinion.
Expert testimony	Direct quotation from a credentialed specialist.	"Professor Nguyen, a paediatric respiratory specialist, calls the air quality 'indefensible'."	Transfers the expert's authority to the writer's case and makes disagreement look like amateur second-guessing.
Eyewitness or vox pop quotation	Quoting ordinary people affected by the issue.	"'I've stopped letting the kids ride to school,' says local parent Dee Halloran."	Grounds the argument in lived experience and suggests broad community agreement.
Personal experience and credentials	The writer establishing their own standing to speak on the issue.	"In twenty-two years as a paramedic in this area, I have never seen it this bad."	Builds ethos, encouraging readers to trust the writer's judgement even where evidence is thin.
Historical precedent	Reference to comparable past events or decisions.	"We made this mistake with the Eastern Freeway in 1977."	Suggests the outcome is predictable, framing the opposition as ignoring the lessons of experience.

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Comparison to other jurisdictions	Citing what other cities, states or countries do.	"Copenhagen solved this a decade ago for a fraction of the cost."	Implies the proposal is proven and low-risk, and that resistance is parochial or lazy.
Official documentation	Quoting legislation, budget papers, minutes or freedom-of-information material.	"The council's own minutes record the risk as 'high and unmitigated'."	Creates the impression of insider knowledge and hard proof, heightening the sense of exposure or scandal.

Reasoning, logic and logical fallacies

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Logical reasoning / cause and effect	A sequence of connected claims leading to a conclusion.	"Fewer services mean longer waits; longer waits mean people drive; more driving means more congestion."	Gives the argument the feel of inevitability, so the conclusion seems to follow whether or not the reader agrees emotionally.
Generalisation	A sweeping claim about a whole group based on limited cases.	"Young people today simply will not take on trade apprenticeships."	Simplifies a complex reality into something the reader can accept quickly, though it invites challenge if noticed.
Slippery slope	Claiming one small step will lead inexorably to an extreme outcome.	"First it is one street closure; soon no one will be able to drive anywhere."	Amplifies fear by attaching disproportionate consequences to a modest proposal.
False dichotomy (either-or)	Presenting only two options when others exist.	"We either fund the upgrade or accept that people will die on this road."	Forces readers into the writer's preferred option by making the alternative appear unthinkable.
Bandwagon	Suggesting that most people already agree.	"More than 9,000 residents have already signed."	Exploits the reader's desire to belong, making dissent feel isolating and eccentric.
Attack / ad hominem	Criticising the person rather than their argument.	"Of course the developer's consultant says it is safe — he is paid to."	Discredits the opposing case by association, so readers dismiss it without weighing its merits.
Straw man	Misrepresenting the opposing position in a weakened form, then refuting it.	"They want to ban cars altogether."	Gives the writer an easy victory and makes the opposition appear extreme.
Circular reasoning	Using the conclusion as its own justification.	"The plan is necessary because without it we would not have a plan."	Can pass unnoticed in fluent prose, leaving readers with a sense of having been given a reason.
Reductio ad absurdum	Following the opposing logic to a ridiculous conclusion.	"By that reasoning we should close the hospital to reduce the road toll."	Exposes the opposition as incoherent and invites the reader to laugh at it.
Post hoc reasoning	Assuming that because one event followed another, it was caused by it.	"Since the speed limit dropped, business on the strip has collapsed."	Offers a simple, satisfying explanation that readers may accept without interrogating the causal link.
Red herring	Introducing an irrelevant issue to divert attention.	Responding to safety concerns by discussing the objectors' political affiliations.	Shifts the ground of debate away from the writer's weakest point.

Tone

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Tone	The writer's attitude towards subject and audience, conveyed through word choice, syntax and imagery.	A measured, reasonable tone throughout an opinion piece on school funding.	Frames how every other technique is received; a reasonable tone makes even forceful claims seem balanced and trustworthy.
Tone shift	A deliberate change of attitude at a specific point in the text.	Moving from wry humour in the opening to grave sincerity in the final paragraph.	Jolts the reader out of comfort and signals that the closing point is the one that matters most.
Outraged / indignant tone	Expressing anger at injustice or incompetence.	"It is an insult — there is no gentler word — to every family on that waiting list."	Licenses the reader's own anger and makes calm acceptance of the status quo feel inadequate.
Reasonable / conciliatory tone	Calm, balanced and willing to acknowledge complexity.	"Reasonable people can disagree here, and many do."	Positions the writer as the sensible voice in a heated debate, making the opposition seem shrill by comparison.

Visual language

Technique	Definition	Example	Intended effect on the reader
Political cartoon	A drawing using caricature, symbolism and captions to make an argument.	A cartoon of a minister padlocking a school gate labelled 'CONSULTATION'.	Delivers a complete argument at a glance and invites readers to enjoy the ridicule of the target.
Caricature and exaggeration	Distorting a figure's features or scale.	A developer drawn with enormous hands clutching a tiny park.	Reduces a person or group to a single unflattering trait, making them easy to dismiss.
Symbolism	Using an object or image to stand for a larger idea.	An hourglass with the last grains falling.	Compresses an abstract claim about urgency into an image readers grasp instantly.
Labelling in cartoons	Written tags attached to figures or objects in an image.	A sinking boat labelled 'PUBLIC TRANSPORT'.	Removes ambiguity, ensuring the reader interprets the image exactly as the cartoonist intends.
Facial expression and body language	The postures and expressions given to figures in an image.	A weary nurse slumped against a corridor wall.	Provokes an immediate empathetic response that bypasses reasoned argument.
Photograph	A selected image accompanying a written text.	A photograph of a flooded classroom.	Offers apparently objective proof while the framing and moment chosen carry the persuasive work.
Gaze and vectors	The direction in which figures look, or lines that lead the eye.	A child looking directly out of the frame at the reader.	Creates a sense of direct address and personal appeal, drawing the reader into the subject's situation.
Salience and size	What is made most visually prominent through scale or placement.	A bulldozer dominating the foreground, protesters tiny behind it.	Establishes a visual hierarchy that mirrors the argument's power relations before any text is read.
Colour	The palette used and the associations it carries.	Sickly greens and greys in an image of a polluted creek.	Sets an emotional register instantly, priming the reader to feel unease or optimism.

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Caption	Text accompanying an image that directs its interpretation.	"The playground, six months after the promised upgrade."	Anchors an ambiguous image to a single reading that supports the written argument.
Graphs and infographics	Data presented visually through charts or diagrams.	A steeply rising line graph of ambulance ramping hours.	Makes a trend look dramatic and self-evident, lending the argument the authority of data.
Layout, subheadings and pull quotes	The visual organisation of a text and the extraction of key lines.	A pull quote in large type: 'Nobody is coming to fix this.'	Guides skim-readers to the most emotive material and gives certain claims disproportionate weight.
Logos and branding	Organisational marks or mastheads within a text.	A hospital foundation logo beside a fundraising appeal.	Borrows established institutional credibility to make the appeal feel legitimate.
Visual juxtaposition	Two contrasting images placed together.	A glossy artist's impression beside a photograph of the actual site.	Invites readers to detect a gap between promise and reality, generating distrust of the opposing side.